

Information Sheet and Volunteer Consent Form

This Informed Consent form is for undergraduate students of Faculty of Medical Sciences, Faculty of Dental Sciences, and Faculty of Allied Health Sciences of University of Sri Jayewardenepura who are invited to participate in a research study on computer vision syndrome. We would like to invite you to take part in our research study titled “Proportion of Computer Vision Syndrome and Associated Factors Among Undergraduates of a Selected State University in Sri Lanka”

Name of Principal Investigator- S. Shaijana

Name of Organization- Faculty of Medical Sciences, University of Sri Jayewardenepura

This Informed Consent Form has two parts:

- Information Sheet (to share information about the research with you)
- Certificate of Consent (for signatures if you agree to take part)

You will be given a copy of the full Informed Consent Form

PART I: Information Sheet

Introduction

We are a group of undergraduate medical students from University of Sri Jayewardenepura. We are conducting a research study on computer vision syndrome, which refers to a group of eye and vision-related problems that result from prolonged use of digital devices, among undergraduate students of a selected state university in Sri Lanka.

We would like to invite you to take part in this study. Before you decide whether to participate, you may take time to think about it and discuss it with anyone you feel comfortable with.

There may be some terms or questions that you do not fully understand. Please feel free to ask us to explain anything at any time. You may also ask questions now or later if anything is unclear.

Purpose of this Research

With the growth of technology, in most parts of the world including Sri Lanka online based working and learning has become an alternative. This has caused a significant increase in screen time among students. By providing a questionnaire with adequate possible symptoms

of CVS we aim to find out the most occurring symptoms the students are vulnerable to, as it will negatively affect visual comfort which can lead to impaired academic performance and overall quality of life.

Though much research has been done on this topic, there are only a few done among Sri Lankan undergraduates to identify the effects of video display terminals on eye health. Hence, this research is planned to study the impact of CVS in medical and allied health faculty students focusing on finding the associated factors that contribute to these symptoms along with their prolonged screen time.

Type of Research Intervention

This study will involve completing a self-administered e questionnaire. Which includes questions about your socio-demographic details, digital screen usage habits, and eye and vision related symptoms. A standardized and pre-tested questionnaire will be used to assess computer vision syndrome.

Participant selection

You are being invited to participate in this study because you are an undergraduate student in a selected state university in Sri Lanka.

Participants are selected from the Faculty of Medical Sciences, Faculty of Dental Sciences, and Faculty of Allied Health Sciences. Students are chosen from different years of study, and both genders to ensure fair representation. Students are chosen randomly from each group in proportion to the number of students in each faculty.

Voluntary Participation

Your participation in this research is entirely voluntary. It is your choice whether to participate or not.

If you decide not to participate, there will be no penalty or any negative impact on your academic activities or relationships within the university.

You may also withdraw from the study at any time, even after agreeing to participate, without giving a reason.

Risks

There are no significant risks associated with this study. Some participants may feel minor discomfort when answering certain questions. You are free to skip any question or stop participating at any time.

All responses will be kept confidential to minimize any risk to your privacy.

Benefits

By participating in this study, you will receive an individual score that indicates your status regarding computer vision syndrome. This can help you understand your risk level and take appropriate measures to protect your eye health.

A scoring system is used to assess your health status on computer vision syndrome and you will get appropriate recommendations to cope with these symptoms as follows

If your score is 7–10 (confirmed CVS cases) you will have to seek consultation with an ophthalmologist or optometrist for further evaluation and management, along with reducing screen time and following recommended ergonomic practices.

If your score is 5–6 (high probability) we encourage you to undergo professional assessment to confirm or exclude the diagnosis and adopt preventive measures.

Students with lower scores (3–4 and 1–2) are advised to follow lifestyle modifications such as limiting screen exposure, maintaining proper viewing habits, and periodic reassessment every six months.

Individuals with a score of 0 need to continue preventive practices. These steps ensure early identification, appropriate referral, and promotion of eye health among participants.

Preventive practices recommended to all participants will include following the 20-20-20 rule (taking a 20-second break every 20 minutes by looking at objects 20 feet away), maintaining proper screen distance (about 50–70 cm) and eye level positioning, ensuring adequate lighting to reduce glare, using anti-glare screens if necessary, adjusting screen brightness and contrast appropriately, maintaining good posture during device use, increasing blink rate to prevent dry eyes, and limiting prolonged continuous screen exposure. These measures aim to reduce the risk and severity of CVS and promote long-term visual health

Confidentiality

All information collected in this study will be kept strictly confidential. Your data will be coded with a unique number instead of using your name, and only the research team will have access to the key linking your number to your identity. All records will be securely stored, ensuring that no one outside the research team can access your personal information.

Right to Refuse or Withdraw

Your participation in this study is completely voluntary. You have the right to refuse to take part or to withdraw from the study at any time, for any reason, without facing any penalty or

loss of benefits to which you are otherwise entitled. Choosing not to participate or to leave the study will not affect your relationship with the university or the researchers in any way.

This study has been approved by the Ethics Review Committee of the Faculty of Medical Sciences, University of Sri Jayewardenepura. If you have any queries or complaints about the conduct of the study, please contact the REC Office on